



THE VOICE EXPRESS

The Truth Takes Time.

THE VOICE EXPRESS GAZETTE

MEDIA

Merchandise

Film critic and former Times Group journalist Mayur Lookhar speaks with TVE correspondent Jia Ahuja about what objectivity actually means inside a media institution — the economics of entertainment journalism, the silence around labour, and what it costs to tell the truth on a platform owned by someone else.

BY MAYUR LOOKHAR

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ABOUT

The Voice Express

The Truth Takes Time.

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*F*ilm critic & ex-Times group journalist Mayur Lookhar - in conversation with TVE correspondent & senior journalism student, Jia Abuja - ungagging the rarely heard voice of the media insider. Mayur offers what is a frank, uncensored, & interesting take on what it means to be objective & authentic as a news producer during both digitization & broadcast's Reign of Economized Terror, particularly with reference to his own sector of the industry - entertainment - & how it plays fast & loose with journalistic ethics more frequently than not in favor of numbers & closings, but nevertheless a worker sympathetic outlook as a journalist himself.

I

"COMMENT ON THE JOURNALISTIC INSISTENCE TO SHOEHORN A CERTAIN KIND OF OBJECTIVITY & NEUTRALITY INTO EVERY NARRATIVE."

MAYUR: So, basically, before I answer here, I wanted to know - these questions that you have come up with - they seem to be fantastic questions, but - what is... you know, what is the thinking behind asking these questions. Is it some kind of an ideology? That makes you ask this? You know, are you coming from some school of objective journalism? Of - you know, the fourth estate, the so called... is that how it is? Do you have a preamble about how journalism should be?

JIA: Yes, sir. And that's what we want your opinion on, like how do you think it should function? Like, there is this narrative that, you know, every story or every piece of journalism should have a certain kind of objectivity or neutrality in its perspective. So, as a journalist, what do you think?

MAYUR: There is no debate, *there is no debate*, that any information - whether it is in the form of news, or a simple communication which you might have with a person, you know, your family & friends, say on WhatsApp group - any information that you put out there has to be objective. Specifically for the media, ideally, the media's job is to be objective.

JIA: Right.

MAYUR: That is what the media was - at least was supposed to, has *meant* to - be through all these years, you know? From the time, you know, basically publishing started, news started. The media's job was to just be objective, neutral. Cover all aspects of a story, get quotes or verify information, put it on - in print. And without taking any side, it has to be objective & neutral, that's it. So, your job was over there. But obviously since we live in 2023, and today - especially with the advent of social media - the technological advancements & especially in the digital age... basically what happens is that the media is divided into different segments. There is broadcast media, there is traditional news media, there is digital media. So, basically, now what's happened is these so-called words, principles - now, they obviously don't hold true for - or maybe they mean different things for each & every medium.

JIA: Could you elaborate on that?

MAYUR: If I were to give you an example of broadcast media - which you yourself as a young student, if you were to follow it, if you asked me what broadcast media is, what is news media today, then for three of the most successful channels it's -
[sighs]

"It's not that on the Broadcast medium you're not supposed to use the 5 W's & 1 H, it's just that you have very little time. The moment you get a scoop, if it is confirmed, you play it. Then, you seek reactions. "Oh! Salman Khan has been arrested." You know, you're speaking to his lawyer, you're speaking to some other actors like Sameer Soni, who was also involved in the alleged crime."

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It's all about the numbers, it's all about the viewership. You know, & that is not news. You can call it noise. But that's the way the game is played today. Because your broadcast audience is not interested in reading about the news. For that, it has its mobile phone, it can subscribe to any digital portal, & he or she will get updates. So, the question of objectivity & neutrality doesn't arise with broadcast media. You know, especially the top private media houses. Because most of them are controlled by corporates (sic). And corporates (sic) have direct or indirect linkages with the political class.

JIA: Right.

MAYUR: So, while obviously it's a wonderful thing, a *morality* thing, that the media's job is to be objective & neutral, but is it in their hands? My question to you would be that. Basically, you just have to play along with the way the tune is being played. So, yeah, definitely from a traditional journalism point of view, at least what you are getting to see on news debates - well, news is no longer news.

JIA: Yeah, that's true.

MAYUR: It's become a debate. Earlier we used to have a civil debate. So that 'civil' has gone out of the question because of - your anchor is someone who's hammering down his agenda, his propaganda to his guest, & your guests are largely fighting. So that's become an info - no, an *entertainment* now. I would say with broadcast media especially, the top brass, the noisy channels, you know, whether it's a Hindi or an English or - of course [I] 've never had the privilege to watch the way that news of other languages is written - but we are largely catering to, you know, a particular ideology, & that's how it is.

II

" 'ALL NEWS, REGARDLESS OF INTENT, WILL ALWAYS BE MANUFACTURED.' DO YOU AGREE? "

MAYUR: What is the definition of a manufacturer? When you ask this question. Do you have any example of it floating in your mind right now? Then maybe I'll be able to understand. I personally never use the word manufacture for news. And since I've largely covered the entertainment beat - though I keep a general knowledge of the general beat, the political thing -

JIA: Right, of course. Could you elaborate on why you refrain from using the term?

MAYUR: Sure. So, manufacturing is a thing, which is not easy, in my humble opinion. If you can maybe give me an example or two, then of course, I can comment on that particular example. A stupid manufactured article may be: an actor is shooting & he suffered a tiny cut. And after some five minutes the actor took first aid, *Dettol lagaye* & he or she is back to shooting. With these kinds of press notes we'd be surprised, so that is kind of manufactured content.

"The concept of breaking news is far from what Broadcast channels will have you believe. Basically, often what happens is - & this is my personal experience, what I have seen when I worked at the desk for a few days - if there is any breaking news, then usually these people bank on the anchors - they [laughing] usually bank on what ANI has published, what PTI has published. You know, they will take information from there & then they will claim that these are our sources. I'm not saying that all the news items on television doesn't - aren't source based - they do have that, as well. But largely what happens is - in a newsroom, there is a breaking leg every - they expect a breaking news in every bulletin, which is not possible."

MAYUR LOOKHAR, 2023

You know, that's what's saleable. That's where the reader is getting value for it. In my personal view, a generalization that everything today is manufactured... no, I don't think so. Because if you read print, & even the digital news, you know, at least the premier - at least the good publications, you know, the Times group, the Indian Express, The Hindu, & The Print, Mr. Shekhar Gupta's The Print^[1] - are these good brands manufacturing content? I don't think so. You are likely to find manufacturing only in, commonly in the digital space, where the journalists are required to, you know, submit these - fulfil these targets. Ten news a day (sic). And that happens in entertainment. [Laughs].

JIA: It does.

MAYUR: I can't comment on the political side because I rarely cover the political beat. At least, in terms of entertainment space, if there are targets to meet for journalists - ten articles a day - plus he or she has to attend one or two events, then in that scenario to meet those targets they will manufacture anything which is flimsy & put it up as news.

JIA: Exactly.

MAYUR: As long as the owner, the company is getting use for it, that is all that matters.

JIA: Well, as you say, in the entertainment industry, news is often manufactured. But in the 24x7 news channels that we have, do you think that new news pieces are available all the time? In case of their absence, what happens?

MAYUR: Ok. So, I'm telling you just my personal experience of having worked for Times Now for two years. The concept of breaking news is far from what Broadcast channels will have you believe. Basically, often what happens is - & this is my personal experience, what I have seen when I worked at the desk for a few days - if there is any breaking news, then usually these people bank on the anchors - they [laughing] usually bank on what ANI has published, what PTI has published. You know, they will take information from there & then they will claim that these are our sources. I'm not saying that all the news items on television doesn't - aren't source based - they do have that, as well. But largely what happens is - in a newsroom, there is a breaking leg every - they expect a breaking news in every bulletin, which is not possible. So, obviously the - broadcast medium works differently.

JIA: Right.

MAYUR: You don't have time, man. You don't have time to - uh, like a print story. You know, you got a scoop, you know you can write one, you know - the first paragraph so & so, you know, so & so thing happened, or this actor got arrested, details awaited, keep watching this piece for more. That you can do in a print, but in a broadcast what are you going to do? You will keep running, you know? "Breaking news, Salman Khan arrested in hit-&-run case," but then you need more details. So, by the time the reporter comes to the ground, whatever plays during that, largely that is whatever the uhh - anchor's mouthing into his/her ear. You can't hold the broadcast medium for that, that kind of waiting period & verifying information, that you can do with a print format or on a digital website better.

JIA: Right.

MAYUR: I hope I'm making sense to you.

JIA: Yes, yes, completely.

MAYUR: Probably, if you speak to somebody who covers a political beat, they'll better be able to explain it to you. This is just what I got from my two years of working with TIMES Now, covering entertainment. I did cover general news, too, a few times, whenever I was asked to. And I found that many a times, I did a better job of general news or politics than the people at the desk, or the anchor who was mouthing. See, the golden rule is just that you have to be aware. You have to read. You don't have to read the entire news articles, but the advantage today with the digital medium is with all these mobile notifications, the moment you start following a particular publication, you keep getting notifications on your phone of your headlines. So, it's not that on the Broadcast medium you're not supposed to use the 5 W's & 1 H, it's just that you have very little time. The moment you get a scoop, if it is confirmed, you play it. Then, you seek reactions. "Oh! Salman Khan has been arrested." You know, you're speaking to his lawyer, you're speaking to some other actors like Sameer Soni, who was also involved in the alleged crime.

JIA: [Laughs]

MAYUR: So, basically the broadcast medium also has its own world. The print medium, you know, because today obviously we'll always be behind digital & broadcast. And digital is like, it's always more volume than quality. It's not that they don't give you quality - they do. But for the news - it's like fast food. It's like if you get something, you write it quick enough, & we'll update the copy later. So, if you call that as manufacturing - I mean, that could be manufacturing - but personally, it's very difficult to manufacture news. You can manufacture a debate, out of a pointless news item. With what you see on news channels these debates, they are basically manufactured content only. You know, you hold onto one particular thing & you stretch it like a chewing gum. That's how it is, ma'am. As per my limited understanding.

Mayur Lookhar is the founder of the entertainment news website, *Beyondbollywood.in^{t21}*, & has over 17 years of experience as an entertainment journalist. He has worked over his career for Times Now, IndianTelevision.com, Cinestaan, BestMediaInfo.com, Sportzinteractive.net, & CineBlitz [freelance] before founding his own portal.

Interviewed by Jia Ahuja.

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